Gauridasa Pandita

Гауридас Пандит · @gauridasa-pandita

Subala of Ambika

In Krishna's eternal pastimes Gauridasa Pandita is Subala, the best of the Lord's dear friends and one of the twelve cowherd boys, the gopalas. Kavi Karnapura says so plainly:

“Subala, the best of the dear friends, is Gauridasa Pandita…”. (GGD 128)

In Gaura-lila these twelve became the companions of Nityananda; they are known precisely as the cowherd friends of Vraja, and all of them hold places of honour in the assembly of the Vaishnavas of the whole world, the Vishva-vaishnava-raja-sabha. Krishnadasa Kaviraja describes them thus:

“All the companions of Sri Nityananda were formerly cowherd boys in Vraja. Each of them had a staff and a horn, they wore the dress of cowherds, and peacock feathers adorned their hair”. (CC, Adi 11.21)

Gauridasa's name never fails to appear in the lists of the twelve gopalas — now fourth, now fifth, for the order of these lists is not the same.

On the tree of Sri Chaitanya, Nityananda is the principal branch:

“Sri Nityananda is the principal branch of Sri Chaitanya's wish-fulfilling tree. From this mighty branch grow many other branches and twigs”. (CC, Adi 11.5)

Krishnadasa Kaviraja bows to all the devotees who grow like twigs upon this principal branch (CC, Adi 11.4). Among them Gauridasa is one of the most important branches, and among Nityananda's companions one of the dearest to Him.

Narahari Chakravarti in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (7.322, 327) calls him Subalachandra, the abode of every virtue, full of prema: the name “Subala — Gauridasa” is known everywhere, he is dear to Nityananda and non-different from Chaitanya[1]. In another verse (7.329) the poet bows to Gauridasa, who was formerly, in Krishna's pastimes, Subalachandra, and is now dear to Krishna-Chaitanya and Nityananda.

He is honoured by various titles: Srila Gauridasa Pandita, Gauridasa Prabhu, Pandita Prabhu, Gauridasa Pandita Gosvami. His brother, the poet Krishnadasa, calls him in his pada Thakura Pandita and “king of panditas” — pandita-raja. In some quotations from the original sources the name is also read “Gauradasa”.

The Sons of Kamsari Mishra

Gauridasa was born in Shaligrama, a village a few miles from Navadvipa, a few kilometres north of Mayapur, near Muragachha station on the Eastern Railway. His father was Kamsari Mishra of the Ghoshal family of the Vatsa gotra; his mother was Kamala Devi. Kamsari had six sons: Damodara, Jagannatha, Suryadasa Sarakhela, Gauridasa — the fourth — Krishnadasa Sarakhela and the youngest, Nrisimha Chaitanya[2].

Gauridasa's elder brother Suryadasa was a man of rare generosity. He served the Muslim rulers, whence his title “Sarakhela”[3], and later gave his two daughters, Vasudha and Jahnava, in marriage to Nityananda. Suryadasa and the younger brother, Krishnadasa, believed in Nityananda with all their hearts:

“Suryadasa Sarakhela and his brother Krishnadasa had unshakable faith in Nityananda. They were filled with love of God”. (CC, Adi 11.25)

Gauridasa's constant support was also King Krishnadasa, son of Raja Harihoda of Badagachhi — the same who undertook to arrange Nityananda's marriage.

The Move to Ambika

With Suryadasa's permission Gauridasa left Shaligrama and settled in Ambika-Kalna on the bank of the Ganga. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (7.330–331) also tells of it: the generous Suryadasa Pandita let his younger brother go, and he moved to Ambika. There he lived in deep renunciation and solitude, giving all his time to the loving service of the Deity of his heart.

The Oar

It was this service that drew Gaurasundara Himself. One day, tradition says, He came to Ambika from Shantipura: He went as far as the village of Harinadi, got into a boat there and, plying the oar Himself, crossed the Ganga.

Then the Lord held out that oar to Gauridasa. “With this I crossed the river,” He said, “and with it you must carry living souls across the river of worldly existence.” Having given him the oar, He embraced His devotee[4]. So it is in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (7.333–336): having sailed from Shantipura by way of Harinadi, the Lord bids Gauridasa ferry the fallen across the river of suffering. The oar became the sign of his service: he is one of those who carry souls to the farther shore, for he bestows on them love for Krishna.

In the courtyard where the Lord sat down to rest there grew a tamarind tree. Beneath it, tradition says, Mahaprabhu and Gauridasa met, and there Gauridasa began to beg the Lord to remain with him in Ambika for ever. The tamarind still stands at the temple entrance.

Returning to Navadvipa, Mahaprabhu took Gauridasa with Him. He also gave him the “Gitamrita”, written in His own hand, and to the end of his days Gauridasa read this gift of the Lord with great reverence[5].

The oar and the book are kept in the temple to this day. By tradition the book is the “Bhagavad-gita” copied out by Mahaprabhu; some scholars doubt it, but the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (7.341) already speaks of it: the fortunate still see, beside the Deities of Ambika, the Gita given by the Lord, and the oar.

The Gaura-Nitai Deities

For Gauridasa, Gaura and Nityananda were everything. Separation from Them even for a moment was to him like the soul's parting from the body, and he sang the qualities of Nitai and Chaitanya ceaselessly, in rapture.

Once Gaura and Nityananda came to take leave of him. This farewell is sung by a contemporary of the events — Gauridasa's brother, the poet Krishnadasa. In the house of Thakura Pandita, Gora dances, whirling round, Nityananda cries “Hari, Hari!”, and Gauridasa falls weeping at the Lord's feet: do not leave my house, stay in Ambika, or I shall die; and if You two brothers stay, all will be saved. The Lord replies:

“Gauridasa, give up such a wish: serve My Deity and you will see — I am present in it, know this for certain; keep this true word of Mine.” (Krishnadasa, PK 2358)

Gauridasa heaved a heavy sigh and wept again; the brothers consoled him, but his heart found no rest.

Then, the poet continues in the next pada, the Lord, seeing his distress, said softly: “We have stayed with you. Know for certain: in this house of yours We two brothers have stayed.” Having consoled him thus, the Lord appeared before the Pandita with two Deities, and the astonished Gauridasa saw four

before him — Gaura and Nitai and Their Deities. And again the Lord said to him:

“Whichever you wish, those two keep in your house. For the sake of your faith I will eat at your house, asking for food — know it in your heart: it is true, true.” (Krishnadasa, PK 2359)

The “king of panditas” set about cooking, and all four partook of the meal; then he offered Them garlands, cloth and betel and anointed Them with sandal paste. Having confirmed his faith in every way, the Lord left Both in his house — for the Pandita's love the two brothers eat there, asking for food — while They Themselves went to Nilachala. The Pandita serves Them, and They play there as They please[6].

Another contemporary, Murari Gupta, tells of the same in the “Kadacha”: at almost the same time as the Lord's Deity was installed in Vishnupriya's house, Gaura and Nityananda came to the house of Gauridasa and gave him Their Deities.

“Bound by his love, They each manifested a lovely, auspicious Deity of Themselves, full of Their own rasas and endowed with every power, and in great delight gave Them to him; dwelling there as They pleased, They partook, together with those two Deities, of food of many tastes”. (“Kadacha” 4.14.13–14)

The Gaura-Nitai Deity is not a likeness or a memorial of the Lord, but He Himself. “I am present in it, know this for certain,” the Lord says in the pada, and in serving the Deities Gauridasa served Gaura and Nitai Themselves.

Later traditions tell it differently[7]. According to one, Gaurasundara, understanding Gauridasa's heart, Himself commanded: “Manifest the Deities of Me and of My brother Nityananda — and We shall fulfil the desire of your heart.” Gauridasa manifested Them; at the sight of Their matchless beauty tears of love streamed from his eyes, and together with those close to him he performed the abhisheka and the other rites, as the shastras prescribe, and raised both Lords to the throne.

According to another tradition, in answer to the plea that He stay, Mahaprabhu revealed to Gauridasa that His form and Nityananda's were hidden in a nim tree growing nearby. Gauridasa understood the sign and had the Gaura-Nitai Deities carved from that tree; Nityananda Himself, they say, was present at the carving. But when Mahaprabhu and Nityananda were about to leave, Gauridasa held Them back with all his strength. The Lord calmed him: “Nityananda and I are directly present in these Deities. Choose: either the Deities go — or We do.” Gauridasa, of course, chose that the “real” Gaura and Nitai should stay — and so it came to pass[8]. The motif of the choice is already in Krishnadasa's pada: “Whichever you wish, those two keep in your house.” The tradition sees in what happened a confirmation of the words of the “Charitamrita”:

“His name, His form and the nature of His personality make up one indivisible truth. Between these three aspects of the Absolute there is no difference — their nature is equally spiritual and blissful”. (CC, Madhya 17.131)

The name, the Deity and the Lord Himself are one; all three are spiritual.

From then on, conquered by Gauridasa's love, the Deities truly ate everything he offered Them. Gaura-Nitai, who love Their devotees, became the captives of his love: he locked Them in the temple of love, and there was no way out for Them.

“Friend Subala”

Once Gaura and Nityananda, smiling tenderly, called him “friend Subala” and reminded him of the cowherd pastimes on the bank of the Yamuna. And at once They showed Themselves to him as They were in Vraja — as Krishna and Balarama: dark and fair, in the dress of cowherd boys, with staffs and

horns, in garlands of forest flowers, with bells on Their ankles; Krishna with His flute and peacock feather. The world around was filled with enchanting beauty, and Gauridasa forgot himself in the bliss of love. For some time They showed him various pastimes, and then by Their own will brought him back to external consciousness and stood once more upon the altar as Gaura and Nitai. Thus the Lord increased his love and awakened in him the mood of Vraja.

Gauridasa cooked for the Deities himself, and both Lords ate his rice and vegetables with great relish. He was so absorbed in this service that he noticed neither bodily comforts nor hardships, and even in old age, grown weak, he would not leave the hearth. Once, having cooked and offered many dishes, he asked Them to eat, but the Lords were silent and did not touch the food. Then Gauridasa, like a true friend, said to Mahaprabhu with vexation: “If You are content without food, why do You make me cook?” — and fell silent himself. The Lord replied: “We asked you not to labour so, yet you still cook so many dishes with such great toil. It pains Us to see your efforts. Cook only what comes easily — We shall accept it gladly.” “Then I shall offer You only rice with greens, shak-anna,” said the Pandita, and from then on the Lords, as They ate, praised his shak[9].

Another time Gauridasa wished to adorn the Deities with jewels — he merely thought of it. The Lord, who knows all hearts, Himself appeared on the throne in wondrous ornaments. Entering the temple and seeing such beauty, Gauridasa fainted with love, and on coming to himself was struck dumb with delight: never had he seen the like — where had They found these ornaments? And how could he now find any such for Them? Knowing his heart, the Lord said: “Ornaments of flowers please Me most of all.” And Gauridasa joyfully decked Them with flowers and, holding a mirror up to Their faces, delighted in Their beauty.

Thus in Gauridasa's house Gaura and Nityananda revealed many pastimes. Later the young Shyamananda would say: Gaura and Nitai ever dwell in the house of Gauridasa. A devotee's love binds the Lord: He gladly eats his simple cooking, puts on ornaments Himself and, as we shall see, goes wherever the love of a disciple calls Him.

Hridaya Chaitanya

One morning Gauridasa came to Gadadhara Pandita Gosvami. Gadadhara seated his guest respectfully and asked what had brought him. “I need Hridayananda,” Gauridasa replied. It pained Gadadhara, but he placed the hand of Hridayananda, dear to him as life, in Gauridasa's hand. Gauridasa brought the youth home, gave him the diksha-mantra and then, pleased with his service, entrusted to him the service of Gaura and Nityananda. Hridayananda became his dearest disciple.

The day of Mahaprabhu's appearance was approaching. Gauridasa told Hridayananda that he would go round the homes of his disciples, collect what was needed for the festival and soon return, and that Hridayananda should serve the Deities with care. He set off with the devotees, absorbed in the bliss of love — and was delayed. Hridayananda grew anxious: plenty of provisions had been gathered, only a few days remained before the festival[10], and the devotees who lived far away still had to be invited. Remembering the feet of his guru, he sent out invitations everywhere himself.

Gauridasa returned on the eve of the festival. Learning of the invitations, he rejoiced at heart but outwardly made a show of anger: “While I am here, you act on your own? Without asking me, you summon anyone you please — even my disciples! You cannot stay here.” Hridayananda bowed at the feet of his guru, went to the bank of the Ganga and sat down under a tree, and Gauridasa began the festival.

Soon a boat carrying a wealthy merchant — a mahajana — put in by Hridayananda, and the merchant handed him a generous offering for his guru[11]. Hridayananda told Gauridasa of it, and the guru bade

him hold the festival right there on the bank. With Vaishnavas gathered from all the country round, Hridayananda began a great sankirtana — and in the midst of the kirtana saw with his own eyes Gaura and Nityananda dancing in love.

Gauridasa heard the roar of the kirtana, and his heart filled with love. He sent the pujari — Bara (the Elder) Gangadasa Pandita — into the temple to serve Gaura and Nityananda. The pujari came back and reported: the Lords are not in the temple, the throne is empty. Gauridasa understood: conquered by Hridayananda's love, They had gone to the bank of the Ganga to kindle his prema still more. With a faint smile he again put on a show of anger and set off there, stick in hand — “so that the brothers do not run away.” Seeing him, Hridayananda fell flat at his feet. Gauridasa saw the Lords dancing; noticing his anger, They vanished unseen by all — and Gauridasa saw Them entering Hridayananda's heart[12].

The stick fell from his hand without his noticing. Overwhelmed with love, Gauridasa embraced his disciple: “You are blessed! From now on your name is Hridaya Chaitanya — he in whose heart is Chaitanya.” He bathed him in tears, while Hridaya lay humbly at his feet. Then Gauridasa led him into the temple courtyard, set him to serve the Deities of Gaura and Nityananda, and together with the Vaishnavas they sang and danced in sankirtana, filling all ten directions with the cry of “Hari!”. So ended the festival of Gauranga's appearance, and Gauridasa blessed Hridaya Chaitanya for the service of the Deities, giving him full right to it — adhikara.

Gauridasa's anger was only an outward play: inwardly he rejoiced, and through this play the glory of the disciple was revealed, the one into whose heart Gaura and Nitai had entered.

From Gauridasa comes a line of disciplic succession. The chief disciple of Hridaya Chaitanya was Shyamananda — the servant of the servant of Subala; after him came Rasikananda, Nayanananda, Radha-Damodara and Baladeva Vidyabhushana; this line is called the line of Nityananda. Hridaya Chaitanya himself, the disciple of Subala-sakha, worshipped Gaura-Nitai in the mood of friendship.

Kinsmen and Guests of Ambika

When Nityananda came for His marriage to the daughters of Suryadasa and embraced His future father-in-law, Gauridasa, looking at his brother, was also overcome with bliss and could not contain his joy.

Gauridasa's house in Ambika became a place to which the Lord's companions and heirs would come; many of these visits fell in the years of Hridaya Chaitanya. Virachandra, Nityananda's son, on his way to Vrindavana at his mother's bidding, came here from Shantipura, and Hridaya Chaitanya received him with warmth and love. Jahnava, on her first pilgrimage, came first of all to Gauridasa's house; Hridaya Chaitanya welcomed her cordially, she cooked an offering for the Gaura-Nitai Deities with her own hands, and after a festival of one night there she went on her way. On the way back from Vraja she came to Ambika again and wept, remembering her uncle, who had by then departed. In a great kirtana Gaura and Nityananda Themselves appeared; at night Jahnava cooked for Them and distributed prasada, and in a dream she saw Gauridasa together with Gaura and Nityananda, and all of them blessed her.

Narottama, after visiting Shantipura, came to Ambika-Kalna, to the house of Gauridasa, where Hridaya Chaitanya was then living. They embraced; Narottama told of the labours of the Gosvamis in Vrindavana and spent a day there. The young Shyamananda, then called Duhkhi, named as his guru Hridaya Chaitanya of Ambika-Kalna, the disciple of Gauridasa Pandita, the companion of Gaura-Nitai. Coming to Ambika, he asked where Gauridasa's house was, bowed down at the temple of Mahaprabhu in that house and there found Hridaya Chaitanya.

Descendants and Heirs

The accounts of Gauridasa's family differ. According to some, he, like Hridaya Chaitanya, had no offspring: those who are now counted as his family are a family of disciples, a shishya-shakha, of Gauridasa or of Hridaya Chaitanya. According to others, Gauridasa's wife was Bimala Devi (so in the “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana”), and he had two sons: the elder, Balarama, called “Bara”, that is, “the big one”, and the younger, Raghunatha; Raghunatha's sons were Mahesha Pandita and Govinda (this Mahesha is not Mahesha Pandita of the twelve gopalas)[13]. Annapurna is held by some to be Gauridasa's daughter, by others Raghunatha's daughter, that is, his granddaughter.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, in the “Anubhashya” on the “Charitamrita” (Adi 11.26), does not accept the genealogy with two sons. According to him, the disciple of Gauridasa was Hridaya Chaitanya Dasa, and Hridaya's disciple was Gopiramana, son of Annapurna Devi, Gauridasa's daughter; the present owners of the shripata in Ambika are descendants of this Gopiramana.

Some kinsmen of Kamsari Mishra's family live in Shaligrama to this day[14].

Departure

Gauridasa's samadhi is in Vrindavana, and from this it is concluded that there he completed his journey in this world. Jahnava, coming to Vraja, saw her uncle's samadhi and burst into tears; the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (11.259) tells of it too. Gauridasa left the world and entered the eternal, unmanifest pastimes of Gauranga and Nityananda.

His departure is honoured on the twelfth lunar day of the bright half of the month of Shravana — the Gaura-dvadashi of the month of Shridhara in the Vaishnava calendar; in 2026 this is 24 August, the same day as the departure of Rupa Gosvami[15].

Narahari Chakravarti set out his whole life and glory in the seventh wave of the “Bhakti-ratnakara”. His memory lives on centuries later: the twentieth-century Vaishnava babaji Vamshidasa, in one of his last days, sang with tears of joy “Nitai and Gaura dance in the house of Gauridasa” and spoke of Kalna and its Amli-tala — the place beneath the tamarind.

The Shripata at Ambika

The shripata of Gauridasa Pandita exists to this day and is well known. Ambika-Kalna lies in Bardhaman district, directly across the Ganga from Shantipura, two miles east of Kalna station on the Eastern Railway; one can reach it by train from Howrah on the line towards Navadvipa. The town takes its name from the locality of Ambika in the Kalna area. The shripata is about one krosha east of Ambika-Kalna.

The temple is faced with white stone; it was built by the zamindar of Bardhaman. At the entrance grows that same tamarind. In the three chambers of the temple are worshipped the Deities of Gauridasa Pandita, Radha-Krishna, Gaura-Nityananda, Jagannatha, Balarama, Sita and Rama[16]. A little to the west of the shripata stand the house and temple of Suryadasa Sarakhela, and further west the ashrama of Bhagavan Dasa Babaji.

Significance

Krishnadasa Kaviraja says of Gauridasa:

“Sri Gauridasa Pandita was endowed with great love and devotion for God. He also possessed tremendous power — he could receive this love and pass it on to others. For the sake of serving Sri Nityananda, Gauridasa gave up the support of his class and family. Thus he accepted Sri Chaitanya and Nityananda as the Lords of his whole life”. (CC, Adi 11.26–27)

Vrindavana Dasa Thakura echoes him:

“Gauridasa Pandita was supremely fortunate, for he surrendered wholly to Nityananda, dedicating his body, mind and speech to His service”. (CB, Antya 5.730)

As Nityananda, as if intoxicated, gave love for Krishna to all without discrimination, so His close companion Gauridasa showed great power in preaching. The oar received from Mahaprabhu's hands was the sign of this power: he carried souls across the river of worldly existence, granting them divine love. His life shows something more: a devotee's love binds the Lord Himself. Gaura-Nitai, who love Their devotees, ate his cooking, adorned Themselves at his mere wish, went after the love of his disciple — and remained in his house for ever.

Let us pray, then, for the mercy of Gauridasa Pandita, Subala of Vraja and companion of Nityananda, whose Lords of life were Sri Chaitanya and Nityananda.

1. “Non-different from Chaitanya” does not mean that the devotee becomes God. Gauridasa is the Lord's eternal friend, and there is nothing in his heart but Gaura and Nitai: in this oneness of love and service he is inseparable from Sri Chaitanya, while remaining His eternal servant and friend.

2. One of the biographies speaks of five brothers.

3. According to one account, Suryadasa was a secretary to the Muslim rulers; according to another, the royal treasurer.

4. According to one account, the Lord had rowed with this very oar; according to another, He brought one of the boat's oars with Him.

5. According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (7.341) and some biographies, the Lord's gift was the “Bhagavad-gita” copied in His own hand; according to another biography, the “Gitamrita”; only the latter says that Mahaprabhu, returning to Navadvipa, took Gauridasa with Him.

6. Accounts differ as to when this happened. According to one biography, the Lord came to take leave of Gauridasa before His sannyasa, after many pastimes in Navadvipa; but in Krishnadasa's pada the Lords go to Nilachala after the farewell, which points to the time after the sannyasa. Murari Gupta (“Kadacha” 4.14) places the gift of the Deities in the days when the Lord, having already taken sannyasa, visited the environs of Navadvipa.

7. How the Deities appeared is told in different ways: according to the “Kadacha”, the Lords Themselves manifested Their Deities and gave Them to Gauridasa; according to Krishnadasa's pada, the Lord came to him with two Deities and bade him keep “whichever two you wish” (one of the biographies retells the pada otherwise: the Lords “manifested Themselves in two murtis” and said, “Your wish is fulfilled”; it also gives the Lord's words as “My murti is the same as I”); according to one later account, Gauridasa manifested the Deities at the Lord's command; according to tradition, the Deities were carved from a nim tree in which the forms of Gaura and Nityananda lay hidden.

8. “Real” here does not mean that the Deity is something less than the Lord. The point of the tradition is the opposite: the Lord Himself and His Deity are one indivisible truth (CC, Madhya 17.131), and Those who stayed with Gauridasa are Gaura and Nitai Themselves. Both the “choice” and the “departure” of the Deities in the tradition are the Lord's play with His loving devotee, not a story that the Deity could be anything other than He Himself.

9. The accounts of the cooking differ in detail. In one, it is Gauridasa himself who speaks with vexation, and the Lord answers, reminding him that He had asked him not to labour so. In another, Gaura and Nitai outwardly grew angry: seeing the old Gauridasa toil, They would not eat; he embraced Them tenderly and asked what he should cook for Them, and the Lord, smiling, said that the cooking was good, but at his age there was no need for so many dishes. Then Gauridasa asked Them to eat what had been cooked that day and promised henceforth to offer a little shak on a fresh banana leaf, and the brothers laughed and ate it all. Only the second account mentions Gauridasa's old age. The vexation and anger here are a play of friendly love (sakhya-rasa), not a worldly emotion.

10. According to one account, two days; according to another, three.

11. According to one account, the merchant arrived with abundant provisions; according to another, he gave Hridaya a large donation with the words “give it to your guru,” and Hridaya brought it to Gauridasa.

12. According to one account, Gauridasa took a stick, according to another a cudgel; on noticing his anger the Lords, by one account, slipped unseen back into the temple, by another became invisible.

13. Only one biography names the wife, citing the “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana”. One of the biographies, having said that Gauridasa had no offspring, at once names his sons and grandsons. Annapurna is Raghunatha's daughter according to one biography; Gauridasa's daughter according to another (on the authority of Bhaktivinoda Thakura) and according to the “Anubhashya”.

14. According to another account, on the authority of Bhaktivinoda Thakura, descendants of Gauridasa himself still live in Shaligrama.

15. So in the Vaishnava calendar of Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math and in one of the biographies; according to another, Gauridasa departed on the eleventh lunar day of the bright half of Shravana (shukla-ekadashi).

16. One description names Mahaprabhu among the temple Deities, another Gaura-Nityananda; a third mentions only the Deities of Gaura-Nityananda.